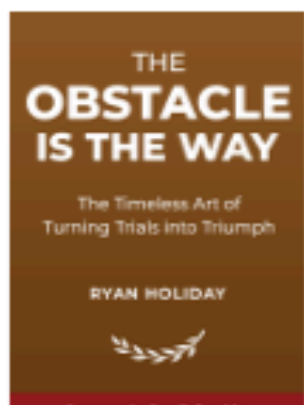




THE OBSTACLE IS THE WAY

The Timeless Art of Turning Trials into Triumph

RYAN HOLIDAY



The Big "So What"

To live to your full potential, you must overcome all sorts of obstacles and convert them to opportunities and strengths. In this book, Ryan Holiday explains how to go about doing that with 3 key disciplines.



Introduction



All of us face obstacles. Such obstacles can be physical (e.g. size or ability), mental (e.g. knowledge or experience), or emotional (e.g. fear or frustration). Obstacles can also be real or perceived. Today, we face more internal obstacles than external ones. Faced with an abundance of options and progress, we've grown comfortable, soft and entitled.



Roman emperor Marcus Aurelius once wrote: "The impediment to action advances action. What stands in the way becomes the way." Successful organizations and individuals aren't crushed by obstacles. They turn adversity to strength to end up even better than before they encountered the obstacles.



In this book, Holiday consolidates his analysis of ancient philosophers' works on Stoicism into practical insights and tips to overcome obstacles. These are broken down into 3 disciplines:

- Perception: how you look at your problems;
- Action: how to tackle problems in actionable parts; and
- Will: how to cultivate your inner being to conquer difficulties.

KEY QUOTES

"Great times are great softeners. Abundance can be its own obstacle, as many people can attest."

"Great individuals, like great companies, find a way to transform weakness into strength."

"Whatever we face, we have a choice: Will we be blocked by obstacles, or will we advance through and over them?"



Part 1: Perception

Your perception is how you interpret what's happening around you. Two people may see and respond differently to the same situation because of varying perceptions. **To turn adversity to strength, the first step is to manage your perceptions.**



Manage your perceptions: calmly observe what's happening, then identify ways to turn things around.

- During the financial crisis of 1857, John D. Rockefeller was still a small-time investor. Despite the mass panic, Rockefeller didn't exit the market. Instead, he calmly saved up, used the opportunity to observe what was going on, and gained critical insights about the financial markets. Thereafter, Rockefeller applied the same composure, discipline and objectivity to invest in oil. Over the next 20 years, he gained control of 90% of the oil in the United States while his competitors languished.
- Don't allow emotional impulses to cloud your judgment. Realize that what others think is bad may not always be so. Look beyond outward appearances to objectively assess what's happening, and identify opportunities others may have overlooked. See the big picture, but focus on areas within your immediate control.

Be Objective



In any event, there are 2 types of stories:

- The objective facts about what actually happened (e.g. you lost money in an investment); and
- Your subjective story (e.g. deciding whether it's "good" or "bad", "fair" or "unfair").



To be objective in your perception, you must remove yourself from the equation. You can pretend that you're giving an advice to a friend, or that the issue isn't important to you.

KEY QUOTES

"Perception precedes action. Right action follows the right perspective."

"We can see opportunity in every disaster, and transform that negative situation into an education, a skill set, or a fortune."

"What matters most is not what these obstacles are but how we see them, how we react to them, and whether we keep our composure."

"Give yourself clarity, not sympathy—there'll be plenty of time for that later."

Acknowledge your Power



In any situation, you *always* have the power to choose your thoughts and responses. You are never powerless or without options.

- In the 1960s, champion boxer Rubin “Hurricane” Carter was convicted of three life sentences for a triple homicide that he didn’t commit. Yet, he didn’t give up. He dedicated his time in prison to work on his legal case, successfully freeing himself 19 years later. Even then, he chose to resume his life rather than seek redress for his unjust prison sentence.
- Despite his limited options, Carter was not powerless, and he chose to use that power to make the best of his situation.



So long as you focus on your options, you can find ways to turn things around. But once you give up, your obstacles would truly have beaten you.

Control your Nerves



Our emotions can get the better of us, especially when we seem to be surrounded by problems, enemies and uncertainty. If you give in to your nerves, you’ll only feel more stressed and overwhelmed. Control yourself: refuse to be intimidated, realize there’s *always* something you can do about the situation, and accept that you must be the one to take control.



Your interpretation affects your perspective. When you react calmly as if something is not a big deal, then it’ll truly not be a big deal.

Don’t Panic



When you panic, you make mistakes, deviate from plans/procedures, and act irrationally. Take control of your emotions; don’t let them control you. Ask yourself: Can this

KEY QUOTES

“Our perceptions are the thing that we’re in complete control of. They can throw us in jail, label us, deprive us of our possessions, but they’ll never control our thoughts, our beliefs, our reactions.”

“There is no good or bad without us, there is only perception. There is the event itself and the story we tell ourselves about what it means.”

“There is always a countermove, always an escape or a way through, so there is no reason to get worked up.”

“Can you fight the urge to panic and instead focus only on what you can change?”

emotion help you to change the situation or issue? If not, don't let it drive you. Instead, use logical questions and statements to identify the root causes so you can make real progress.



Things that're unfamiliar tend to seem more fearful. By repeatedly practicing your responses to specific challenges, you can train yourself to overcome your fears, and become less likely to panic in similar situations. NASA trains its astronauts by simulating the space environment and likely events, then getting the astronauts to practice the details over and over until they can handle them calmly and intuitively.

Modify your Perspective



You're free to change your perspective, since you are the one who decides what it should be. Shift your perspective by (i) changing the *context* to see the bigger picture and/or (ii) *reframing* how you choose to interpret an event. In his early years in Hollywood, actor George Clooney faced numerous rejections and blamed the system for not recognizing his talent. Things changed after he realized that *he* was responsible for showing that he was perfect for a role. Thereafter, he made it a point to prove himself in auditions, preproduction, filming etc., and transformed his results.



Minor shifts in viewpoints can make a huge difference. For example, if you think "I am bad at writing", you make yourself the problem instead of the task at hand, which is to finish your writing.

Focus on What You Can Do



There're many things in life that're out of our control, e.g. the weather, other people's reactions, or the economy. You can choose to complain and feel helpless, or you can choose to find ways to overcome your obstacles and gain power in the process. In 1974, legendary baseball player Tommy John suffered a major injury to his pitching arm that should've ended his baseball career. Yet, he refused to give up.

KEY QUOTES

"With enough exposure, you can adapt out those perfectly ordinary, even innate, fears that are bred mostly from unfamiliarity."

"The right perspective has a strange way of cutting obstacles—and adversity—down to size."

"When you can break apart something, or look at it from some new angle, it loses its power over you."

"To argue, to complain, or worse, to just give up, these are choices. Choices that more often than not, do nothing to get us across the finish line."

He discovered that he had a 1 in 100 chance of recovery if he underwent an experimental surgery and rehab. He took that chance, recovered, and won 164 more games over the next 13 seasons.



Don't waste energy and effort resisting what has happened or complaining about things you can't change. Focus 100% on the things you *can* change. Even if it offers just a 1% chance of success, use it to make a difference.

Focus on the Now



Don't overthink an issue by dwelling on the past, worrying about the future, or trying to find the meaning behind everything that exists or happens. The reasons you *think* are behind your obstacles are just your unproven theories. For instance, disadvantages don't necessarily set you back, since half of all Fortune 500 companies were actually started during a recession or bear market.



Focus on the present moment and how to make the most of your time *now*. Remove distracting thoughts from your mind through meditation, exercise or other methods. Focus on what you can do in the present, and move forward one step at a time.

Think Outside the Box



When someone gives us a seemingly-impossible task, we tend to argue and complain. The truth is, you can get *anything* done if you truly set your mind to it. A week before the launch of the first Macintosh computer, the engineers at Apple told Steve Jobs that they needed an extra week to finish the project. Jobs calmly told them that if they could do something in 2 weeks, they could very well do it in 1 week. The engineers pushed ahead and completed the Mac in time.



Don't settle for mediocracy or let others define what's "possible" for you. Dare to stand out from the crowd and challenge yourself to aim high. In fact, you're likely to be the

KEY QUOTES

"Focusing exclusively on what is in our power magnifies and enhances our power."

"Those who survive...survive because they took things day by day—that's the real secret."

"Focus on what is in front of you, right now."

"Our perceptions determine, to an incredibly large degree, what we are and are not capable of."

"Our best ideas come... where obstacles illuminate new options."

most creative when you're *forced* to come up with a novel solution against the odds.

Look for the Opportunity in the Problem



In any situation or problem, there'll always be opportunities. Once you're in control of your emotions, you can find ways to flip something seemingly-negative into something positive.

- During WWII, the Germans used the Blitzkrieg maneuver to send large, concentrated numbers of troops tearing into the Allied formations like the tip of a spear. Each time, the incoming German troops seemed so overwhelming that the Allied forces panicked and scattered.
- American general Dwight Eisenhower stayed calm in face of the disaster and found an opportunity in the obstacle. In the subsequent battles, the Allied troops deliberately allowed the German army wedge to enter their formation, then encircled them from the rear to attack them from all sides. This became the turning point of the war.



Obstacles are always opportunities for growth. A bad boss could push you to find a better job elsewhere. A rival could motivate you to up your game. A business mistake teaches you that your hypothesis is wrong. In fact, many athletes who suffered a major injury or adversity ended up improving in those very areas—a phenomenon known as adversarial or post-traumatic growth. Learn to turn adversity into opportunity.



Part 2: Action

Once you have your perceptions and emotions under control, you're ready to take real action.



In face of a tough challenge, you can procrastinate, avoid the problem, feel sorry for yourself or make the most of the situation. In the end, a problem will only be as bad as you make it out to be.

KEY QUOTES

"Seeing through the negative, past its underside, and into its corollary: the positive."

"There is good in everything, if only we look for it"
- Laura Ingalls Wilder

"A clearer head makes for steadier hands"

- Famous Greek orator, Demosthenes, was a sickly child with a serious speech impediment. He lost his father at the age of 7 and his inheritance was stolen by his guardians. Instead of wallowing in self-pity, Demosthenes took extreme measures to conquer his obstacles. To overcome his speech impediment and strengthen his voice, he practiced speaking with his mouth full of pebbles or while running up steep slopes. Instead of going out to play, he locked himself underground to self-study.
- Demosthenes eventually won a suit against his guardians, got back what was left of his inheritance, and went on to become a great orator. He was dealt a bad hand in life, but chose to take action and turn his challenges into strengths.

Stay in Motion



To achieve a goal and overcome obstacles, you must grasp any opportunity to get started, then keep moving. Don't wait for the perfect opportunity, nor allow fear or self-doubt to stop you from taking the first steps.

- Amelia Earhart dreamed of becoming a pilot—a seemingly impossible goal in the 1920s when gender discrimination was rife. Her first piloting opportunity was far from ideal: she had to be supervised by male chaperones and wouldn't even be paid. Still, she grabbed the chance. This crucial first step led to many other opportunities and each time, Amelia said “yes”.
- Five years later, Amelia became the first woman to fly solo across the Atlantic. This was only possible because she made the most of every opportunity to move forward and build momentum.



Any opportunity is a good starting point, as it can lead to new options down the road. Keep saying yes, and stay in motion until you reach your goal.

KEY QUOTES

“The proper perception—objective, rational, ambitious, clean—isolates the obstacle and exposes it for what it is.”

“It matters what you do with what happens and what you’ve been given.”

“You’ve got to start, to go anywhere.”

Persist till you find a Solution



Innovation requires persistence. Often, you must exhaust all obvious options before you'll discover a new solution. During the United States Civil War, General Ulysses Grant tried without success to penetrate Vicksburg's defences. After trying almost every known military strategy for close to a year, he finally decided to try the unknown—his troops left most of their supplies behind, crossed the river and lived off the enemy lands as they conquered them. Eventually, they broke the enemy's will and succeeded.



Know that there's always a solution that works—all you need to do is persist long enough to find it.

KEY QUOTES

"Genius often really is just persistence in disguise."

Fail Forward



There's nothing shameful about failing. Failure is actually an asset if you use it to learn what doesn't work and how to improve. Failure is only bad when you don't learn from it.



In Silicon Valley, start-ups launch with Minimum Viable Products (MVPs) instead of finished products. They use the MVPs (with only 1-2 core features) to test customers' responses, so they can fail cheaply, make adjustments quickly and move on to test the next iterations. Use the same approach in your life—turn every failure into an opportunity by using the lessons to reflect, re-evaluate, and recreate, over and over again. Iterate your way to success.

"The one way to guarantee we don't benefit from failure—to ensure it is a bad thing—is to not learn from it."

"Failure shows us the way—by showing us what isn't the way."

Take One Step at a Time



Every goal is achieved via a series of steps. To realize your goal, you need to define and focus on the process required to get there. Don't worry about the end-results, e.g. winning a championship. Instead, focus on the task at hand, e.g. finishing a drill or workout.

"Follow the process and not the prize."



Break down a complex goal into small steps. Instead of an overwhelming feat, you now have small, manageable tasks that you can accomplish, one at a time. Instead of wasting energy fretting and struggling, channel your energy to what you must do now, and focus on finishing it well.

Do Every Job Well



Approach every task with pride, dedication and respect. No matter how big or small a task, be guided by these 3 principles: do your best, be honest, and create the best possible impact.

- There is no shame in any job unless you don't do it well. Don't get so preoccupied with the future that you lose sight of your present task. Never cut corners just because no one is watching, if there's no direct gain or if you think it's a menial task.
- President James Garfield paid for his college tuition by working as a janitor. He did his job with a smile and absolutely no shame. He was equally committed to excellence as a janitor and in his studies, quickly becoming a professor within a year and the dean by the age of 26.



Everything you do matters. Each task and action adds up to define who you are and what your life means.

The "Right" Approach is What Works



There is no one "right" approach to solving a problem. Go for the approach that works instead of rigidly following others' rules. In 1915, two companies wanted to buy land in South America, which 2 tribes claimed to own. The larger corporation devoted its resources to researching the true owner, while the smaller company cleverly paid *both* tribes for the property. In the end, they paid double for the land, but beat the larger company to achieve their goal.



Be pragmatic. Do what you can with what you have. Focus on getting results rather than on idealistic or perfect methods.

KEY QUOTES

"The process is about doing the right things, right now."

"Wherever we are, whatever we're doing and wherever we are going, we owe it to ourselves, to our art, to the world to do it well."

"Forget the rule book, settle the issue."

"Pragmatism is not so much realism as flexibility."

Choose Strategy over Brute Force



The best solution is seldom the grandest nor the most direct. In fact, it's usually ineffective to fight something head-on. When George Washington was a general, he kept the upper hand by using unconventional tactics, e.g. ambushing enemies when they were drunk, withdrawing his troops unexpectedly, or attacking from the flanks.



When you find yourself struggling and straining to reach a goal, step back to explore alternatives. Rather than butt heads with your obstacle, devise a plan: use your strengths, find leverage and go around the obstacle. Fight smart, not hard.

Let Obstacles Eliminate Themselves



When there's no way to confront or even go around a problem, it may be best to let the problem work against itself. Alexander the Great succeeded in taming his horse Bucephalus where no one else could—instead of trying to force him with whips and ropes, he simply mounted and hung on while the horse tired himself out.



When you push too hard for a goal (e.g. securing a new client or a pay raise), it can backfire. It takes humility and patience to recognize your limitations, change your course or bide your time. Sometimes, inaction is in itself an action; the best way forward may be to stand still, move sideways or even backwards.

Put your Frustration to Work



Rules, limits and obstacles can be frustrating. We can complain about them, react impulsively, or channel the energy into productive action. Like any tennis player, Arthur Ashe experienced his share of pressure and frustration. However, instead of throwing tantrums, he remained outwardly calm and redirected the energy into bursts of speed and power in his tennis moves.

KEY QUOTES

"The way that works isn't always the most impressive."

"Instead of fighting obstacles, find a means of making them defeat themselves."

"Adversity can harden you. Or it can loosen you up and make you better—if you let it."



When things go wrong, don't act recklessly from anger and frustration. Stay in control and deploy that energy to achieve your goals in constructive ways.

Use Adversity to your Advantage



Crises are often great opportunities to turn things around. Instead of cowering or giving up, look for unique openings to catapult yourself forward. In 2008, Barack Obama almost lost the presidential primary elections after controversial comments from his childhood pastor. He seized the opportunity to address the delicate issue of racial inequalities in his speech "A More Perfect Union". This became a pivotal point in his campaign—Obama went on to win the election and serve two terms as president.



Reframe your problems and use adversity as a springboard for action. If you're bedridden, consider writing that novel you've always wanted to. If you're retrenched, why not use the chance to launch your own business? Find and seize the opportunity in adversity.



Part 3: Will

Even with Perception and Action, you will still encounter unexpected trials in life. **To endure and prevail, you must cultivate the will (or inner power) to confront obstacles over and over again.**



Strong willpower isn't about forcing your way through something. It's about knowing that you can/will fail, yet taking the right, consistent actions regardless.

- Abraham Lincoln, the 16th president of the United States, faced countless obstacles in his life. He had to struggle with poverty, the loss of both his mother and the woman he loved, educate himself, manage politics, depression, civil war and the fight against slavery.
- Through it all, he shouldered his burdens, found meaning in his struggles, and willed himself to keep going. In fact,

KEY QUOTES

*"[A] crisis provides the opportunity for us to do things that you could not do before."
—Rahm Emanuel*

"It's at the seemingly bad moments, when people least expect it, that we can act swiftly and unexpectedly to pull off a big victory."

"Will is our internal power, which can never be affected by the outside world."

"We can think, act, and finally adjust to a world that is inherently unpredictable. The will is what prepares us for this, protects us against it, and allows us to thrive and be happy in spite of it."

Lincoln's own suffering made him a more compassionate person. His favorite line was, "This too shall pass".

Use Good Times to Prepare for Bad Times



▶ You'll face adversity no matter what you do. Prepare yourself mentally ahead of time, so you can withstand future obstacles. As a child, Theodore Roosevelt suffered from life-threatening asthma, but cured himself after years of rigorous, daily workouts in the gym. This early training provided the mental strength and foundation to help him endure numerous challenges later in life, including the death of loved ones, political woes and even assassination attempts.

💪 The Stoics used the term "Inner Citadel" to describe an inner fortress that can't be breached by outside forces. Build your mind and body during good times so you can withstand the blows during bad times.

Plan for your Failures



🔍 Things *will* go wrong, but you don't have to be caught off guard when they do. Don't just do post-mortems to evaluate past failures. Use pre-mortems (a concept by psychologist Gary Klein) to identify possible failures *before* you start a project.

⚠️ Anticipate failure before it happens, so you're prepared for specific obstacles, or can at least manage your expectations so you won't be stumped by unforeseen events.

Accept your Problems



👣 When you face challenges beyond your control, don't give up. Accept them and move on. Thomas Jefferson accepted his speech impediment, but didn't allow it to hold him back from his dream of being a politician. Instead of trying to become a great orator, he focused on cultivating his strength in writing, and became one of the most prolific writers of his time.

KEY QUOTES

"Nobody is born with a steel backbone. We have to forge that ourselves."

"When the cause of our problem lies outside of us, we are better for accepting it and moving on."

 Constraints can be blessings in disguise as they push us to explore new skills and solutions. Accept your weaknesses so you can address them and forge new paths which you may not otherwise have considered.

Love Everything, including your Obstacles



 Be grateful for your problems and the opportunities they bring. The Romans dubbed this *amor fati*, a "love of fate". When Thomas Edison was told that his house and labs (along with his years of research and prototypes) were on fire, he didn't despair. Knowing he couldn't reverse the event, he called his family to enjoy the beautiful, colourful fire being produced from the lab chemicals. Then, he rebuilt everything with vigor. Within 1 year, he made back 10x of what was lost.

 Accepting something is better than feeling bitter and frustrated. But, the *best* response is to embrace the situation and take action cheerfully to create the biggest possible impact.

Persevere Till the End



 Persistence is about sticking it out till you overcome an obstacle. Perseverance is about confronting obstacle after obstacle, never giving up no matter how many rounds of problems you face. After 10 years at war, legendary Greek hero Odysseus was blown away from his homeland just before reaching its shores. He persevered through another 10 years of life-threatening trials before he eventually made it home.

 Know that you are capable of overcoming anything with unassailable will and purpose. Be prepared to play the long game.

KEY QUOTES

"We don't get to choose what happens to us, but we can always choose how we feel about it."

"Perseverance is something larger. It's the long game. It's about what happens not just in round one but in round two and every round after...until the end."

Focus on Helping Others



When you're facing a huge challenge, focusing on yourself will only make you feel all alone, leading to despair and hopelessness. However, when you focus on a wider purpose or how your actions will impact others, it distracts you from your own fears/pain and gives you strength to go on. When Commander James Stockdale was captured during the Vietnam War, he knew that he'd inevitably be tortured for information. Instead of worrying about his own survival, he focused on his mission and role as a leader. He used his energy to create a support network amongst his fellow prisoners, gave them a purpose and helped them (and himself) to survive the dire situation.



Strength is more easily found in service to others. Fortify your will by focusing on something bigger than yourself.

Contemplate Death



Every human being will die. In fact, you could die at any moment without warning. Contemplate mortality by asking yourself: what would you do if you only had a short period left to live? Then, live your life as if that were the case. After nearly dying in a horse-riding accident, French nobleman Michel de Montaigne stopped fearing death. He embraced life and went on to become a famous writer, mayor, dignitary, and royal confidante.



Use your mortality to create urgency. Seize the day and live intentionally. When you can embrace death—the biggest possible obstacle in your life—all other challenges will seem small in comparison.

Embrace the Cycle of Life



Life will never stop throwing you challenges. In fact, the more you achieve, the bigger the challenges you'll face. Don't delude yourself into thinking that you'll ever be problem-free. Instead, pace yourself, keep things in perspective, continuously take action and grow

KEY QUOTES

"Lend a hand to others. Be strong for them, and it will make you stronger."

"Shared purpose gives us strength."

"Death doesn't make life pointless, but rather purposeful."

"See things for what they are. Do what we can. Endure and bear what we must."

stronger with every obstacle you conquer. Combine Perception, Action and Will, and let the obstacles lead the way.



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

In this book, Holiday presents a series of stories and citations to show you how to perceive, take action and persevere in face of obstacles. In this summary, we've only outlined the key ideas and selected examples. For more details, please visit <https://ryanholiday.net/>.

About the Author



Ryan Holiday (born 1987) is an American author, marketer, entrepreneur and founder of Brass Check (a creative advisory firm). He began his professional career at the age of 19, and is a media strategist, a former director of marketing for American Apparel and a media columnist and editor-at-large for the New York Observer. Holiday has been credited by the New York Times with the increasing popularity of stoicism.

KEY QUOTES